Zhuokun Liu

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CONTACT INFORMATION

Goethe University Frankfurt
Theodor-W.-Adorno-Platz 4
Frankfurt am Main, 60323
Germany

Phone: +49 162 1552547
E-mail: zhuokun.liu@econ.uni-frankfurt.de
Website: zhuokun-liu.com

RESEARCH FIELDS Behavioral and Experimental Economics

CURRENT POSITION

Research Assistant 2021 –
Chair of Applied Microeconomics (Prof. Dr. Ferdinand von Siemens)
Goethe University Frankfurt

AFFILIATIONS

Frankfurt Laboratory for Experimental Economic Research (FLEX) 2021 –

EDUCATION

Goethe University Frankfurt
Ph.D. in Economics (Expected) 2026
M.Sc. in Quantitative Economics 2025

Jacobs University Bremen
B.A. in International Business Administration 2019
(Minor in Industrial Engineering and Management)

Rice University
Visiting Undergraduate 2018

WORKING PAPERS

From Individual Information to Group Beliefs: Memory, Aggregation, and Stereotype Persistence
(with Huen Tat Au-Yeung)

We study why individual information that contradicts stereotypes may have a limited influence on group beliefs. We distinguish two cognitive frictions: imperfect memory of individual performance and imperfect aggregation of individual assessments into group assessments. In two online experiments, subjects graded students on a car-knowledge quiz and reported their predicted and recalled performance, individually and by gender. We randomly vary access to grading records to manipulate reliance on memory. When women outperform men, hiding records makes group predictions more male-favoring. Yet making records available does not ensure that group assessments reflect all individual information equally. Even with visible records, directly reported group predictions and recall imply more male-favoring gender gaps than those aggregated from individual assessments. This wedge suggests information reflected in individual assessments may not be aggregated accurately in group assessments. To facilitate aggregation, we test an intervention that first elicits all individual predictions and displays them when subjects make group predictions. When within-gender performance variation is low, this intervention offsets 67% of the effect of hiding records on the gender gap from directly reported group predictions.

Communication and the Polarization of Trust Attitudes
(with Ferdinand von Siemens)

Many economic interactions require trust, and judgments about whether to trust are often formed in conversation with peers. We study whether this social process polarizes trust. In an online experiment, we randomly vary whether trustors communicate with another trustor before or after making decisions in separate trust games. Chat partners make individual choices and have independent payoffs. Our results show that communication reduces the variation in trust within, while increasing trust differencesbetween the chat groups, thus leading to a polarization of trust cultures. We further find that groups that develop strong positive trust cultures focus in their discussions on both moral principles and self-interest. Our findings identify peer communication as a source of distinct local trust cultures: willingness to trust depends not only on individual predispositions but also on the social setting in which judgments about others are formed.

Misleading Graphs

Graphs can distort inference even when they display accurate numbers. In a between-subject experiment, 1,045 participants update beliefs about an unknown state after observing a signal. They receive identical information as numbers, standard bar charts, or charts with one truncated axis. Truncation raises average absolute error by 1.48 percentage points, about 12 percent relative to standard charts, and increases disagreement. It also lowers the probability assigned to the state represented by the truncated chart when the observed signal is rare in that state. A two-stage model links these shifts to visual distortion of the evidence before belief updating. Structural estimates capture this directional pattern alongside a general tendency to underreact. The findings show how graphical presentation changes the use of information and reduces inference accuracy without changing the disclosed facts.

GRANTS AND AWARDS

The Royal Swedish Academy of Sciences
Co-PI (with Huen Tat Au-Yeung), research grant — 128,272 SEK 2025

Goethe University Frankfurt
Travel grant (VFF Förderung) — 800 EUR 2026
Travel grant (Forschungstopf) — 1,000 EUR 2026
Research grant (VFF Förderung) — 800 EUR 2025
Research grant (Forschungstopf) — 3,200 EUR 2025
Travel grant (Forschungstopf) — 700 EUR 2024
Research grant (Forschungstopf) — 3,240 EUR 2023
Research grant (VFF Förderung) — 800 EUR 2023

The Leibniz Institute for Financial Research SAFE
Co-PI (with Huen Tat Au-Yeung), research grant — 3,000 EUR 2024

Jacobs University Bremen
Study Abroad Scholarship 2018

SEMINAR AND CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS (INCLUDING SCHEDULED)

2026
Conferences:
Workshop on Dynamic Decision Making: Minds, Models, and Markets (Sydney)
Economic Science Association Asia-Pacific Meeting (Melbourne)
The 4th Wuhan Cherry Blossom Workshop on Experimental Economics (Wuhan)

2025

Conferences:
The 17th Nordic Conference in Behavioral and Experimental Economics (Stavanger)
Science of Decision Making Conference (Chengdu)
Behavioral, Experimental and Theoretical Economics Conference (Beijing)
Economic Science Association World Meeting (Beijing)
Young Economists' Meeting (Brno)

Seminars:
Jinan University (Guangzhou)
Central University of Finance and Economics (Beijing)

2024

Conferences:
Verona Experimental Meeting (Verona)
The 13th Southern Europe Experimental Team's Meeting (Málaga)

TEACHING

Goethe University Frankfurt

Instructor

- Academic Writing Seminar (B.Sc. Seminar) — Summer 2026

Teaching Assistant

- Fundamentals of Microeconomics (M.Sc.) — Winter 2021 — 2026
- Management 1 (B.Sc.) — Summer 2026
- Behavioral Organizational Economics (B.Sc. Seminar) — Winter 2025
- The Economics of Social Media (M.Sc. Seminar) — Winter 2022, 2023, 2024
- Microeconomics 2 (B.Sc.) — Summer 2024
- Decision Making in Markets and Organizations (B.Sc.) — Summer 2023
- Organizational Economics (M.Sc.) — Summer 2021, 2022
- Advanced Topics in Experimental Organizational Economics (M.Sc. Seminar) — Winter 2021

Thesis Supervisor

- Bachelor Thesis (15)
- Master Thesis (10)

PROFESSIONAL ACTIVITIES

Applied Microeconomics and Organization Seminar — 2023 –
Co-organizer, Goethe University Frankfurt

Management and Microeconomics Brown Bag Seminar — 2022 –
Organizer, Goethe University Frankfurt

Annual Meeting of the Committee for Organizational Economics — 2022
Co-organizer, Frankfurt

TECHNICAL SKILLS

LaTeX, ORSEE, oTree, Python, Stata

LANGUAGES

English (fluent), Chinese (native), German (intermediate), Japanese (intermediate)

PERSONAL INFORMATION

Born in 1999
Citizenship: Chinese, German permanent resident (Niederlassungserlaubnis)

REFERENCES

Ferdinand von Siemens (Main advisor)
Goethe University Frankfurt
Theodor-W.-Adorno-Platz 4
60323 Frankfurt am Main
vonsiemens@econ.uni-frankfurt.de

Frederik Schwerter
Frankfurt School of Finance and Management
Adickesallee 32-34
60322 Frankfurt am Main
f.schwerter@fs.de

Peter Andre
Leibniz Institute for Financial Research SAFE
Theodor-W.-Adorno-Platz 3
60323 Frankfurt am Main
andre@safe-frankfurt.de